

INDIA PICTURE

M. Balamuralikrishna

(1930-2016)

On no one would the word genius fit as well as on Balamuralikrishna. Actor, composer, no mean hand on the viola, violin and mridangam—and, above all, that singing. Besides being a charismatic star within the grammar-bound world of Carnatic, daring to make original creations, no one contributed as much as him to its passage beyond conventional audiences with crossover jugalbandis alongside Hindustani masters.

BCCL



Vidwaan Mandolin U. Srinivas

(1969-2014)

The child prodigy fulfilled his own promise before departing, too early, at age 45—a self-hewn virtuoso who became so synonymous with an instrument that it adorned his name. That too a western one with a primarily folk footprint. How Srinivas eked out the gamaka-laden melodic complexities of Carnatic from his mandolin—and made it sound so haunting and magical—is a marvel of nature.



Ustad Alla Rakha

(1919-2000)

The waxing and waning of his tala in sync with Pt Ravi Shankar's raga showers at festivals like Monterey Pop, Woodstock and Concert for Bangladesh are part of global music lore, giving the tabla an aura that will never dim. Judge only by Grateful Dead drummer Mickey Hart's words: "Ustad Alla Rakha is the Einstein, the Picasso; he is the highest form of rhythmic development on this planet."